

The Auwa Figure — Rieko's Guide

26 August 2026. Everything needed to make the first edition of 30. The figure is Rieko's project end to end: she prints, sands, stains, finishes, signs, packs and sources. Tom guides, photographs, prices and sells. Full background in `context/business/figure.md`.

WHAT WE ARE MAKING

Thirty Auwa figures, hand-finished, signed and numbered, sold once and never made again.

Fifteen **Natural** (pale wood) and fifteen **Sumi** (near-black). Each one is 10cm tall, printed in Bambu PLA Wood, sanded smooth by hand, finished with wax, seated on a turned wooden base, and packed in a Japanese paulownia box with a hand-written card.

Two hours of work per figure. Sixty to seventy-five hours in total. Sold to order over about three weeks, not made in advance.

PART 1 — THREE THINGS TO DECIDE FIRST

Nothing else can be finished until these are settled.

1. Is the black Auwa a character, or just a colour?

You are planning a black Auwa in the books. If the black exists in the stories, then these are two characters, not one figure in two colours. That is a much stronger thing to sell, and each one gets its own name.

Why it matters: it decides the names, the words on the website, and how the thirty are split.

2. Freeze the shape at 10cm.

Pick a date, and after that date no more changes to the model.

Why it matters: the base is made to fit the figure, and the box is made to fit the base. Any change to the figure means re-ordering both, and both are made by other people who take weeks.

3. Write down the eyes.

Exact size, exact position, exact colour, for both versions.

Why it matters: a face is the first thing anyone looks at, and across thirty figures the eye notices any difference immediately. Decide once, then copy it. Do not judge it fresh each time.

PART 2 — SIX TESTS

Do these one at a time, changing only one thing in each test. Keep every test piece and label it.

Test 1 — Layer height. Print the same figure twice, once at 0.2mm and once at 0.08mm layers. Sand both.

Why: thinner layers take much longer to print, but the machine does that work while you sleep. Thicker layers take minutes to print and then cost you an hour of sanding. We want to trade machine time for your hands. Find out how much sanding the fine layers actually save.

Test 2 — Sanding time. Sand one figure properly, all the way, and time yourself with a clock.

Why: this single number decides the whole schedule. If it is 45 minutes, thirty figures is three full weeks of your hands and we plan differently.

Use sandpaper in order: 180, then 320, then 400, then 600. Wrap the paper around a small foam block for the curved body. The hardest places are under the arms and between the legs. Pay attention to the very top of the head, where the print leaves a small mark where the layers meet. That mark is on every single print and it must be sanded away.

Test 3 — Staining, for the Sumi. Test wood stain on White Oak prints and on Black Walnut prints. Try several strengths.

Why: we want near-black, but with the wood grain still visible underneath. That means the black one is the same material as the natural one, just finished differently, which is a much better story than using two different plastics. If stain will not work, we use hand-applied matte black paint instead and describe it honestly as a paint.

Test 4 — Finish. Sand three pieces the same way. Leave one bare, oil one with camellia oil, wax one with clear matte hard wax. Buff the waxed one dry.

Why: bare wood-plastic picks up finger marks and slowly yellows in daylight. Oil darkens the colour and makes it shiny, which is what we disliked on the allPHA test. Wax should keep the dry

chalky look and still seal the surface. Choose by touch, not by photograph.

Test 5 — The number. Add the edition number to the 3D model, on the underside of the body between the legs, and print it.

Why: the number must be on the figure itself, not only on the base, because a base could be swapped. Since we print each figure separately anyway, adding the number in the model costs one minute in the slicer and makes it permanent. Check it comes out clean and readable at small size.

Test 6 — Posting. Pack one figure exactly as we would sell it, and post it to a friend in another country. Ask them to photograph it as they open it.

Why: the legs are thin and the material is brittle. We need to know now whether it survives a courier, not in December with thirty orders paid for.

Also worth checking: weigh a finished figure. If it feels too light in the hand, we can add a little steel shot inside through a small hole in the base of the body and glue a cap over it. Light objects feel cheap, and it takes three minutes.

PART 3 — WHAT TO BUY

- Bambu **PLA Wood White Oak (13106)** — enough for 40 figures, about 3kg
 - Bambu **PLA Wood Black Walnut (13107)** — one spool for stain testing
 - A **hardened steel nozzle** if not already fitted. Wood filament wears normal nozzles out and can block them
 - Sandpaper: 180, 320, 400, 600 grit, plus small foam sanding blocks
 - **Wood stain**, dark or ebony, water-based, small tins in two or three strengths
 - **Clear matte hard wax** (paste wax), and soft cloths for buffing
 - Camellia oil (tsubaki), small bottle, for the finish test only
 - Fine paintbrushes for the eyes
 - Wool felt sheet, natural undyed, for the cradle inside the box
 - Undyed cotton or washi sheets for wrapping, enough for 40
 - Good card stock for the hand-written cards
 - Plain outer cardboard cartons and void fill, enough for 40
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PART 4 — WHAT TO ORDER FROM OTHER PEOPLE

Start these now. They take the longest and everything else waits on them.

1. The paulownia box (桐箱, kiribako)

Ask for: roughly **14cm x 14cm x 10-11cm tall**, walls thicker than a food box, a properly fitted lid (the kind that sinks slowly because the air has to escape), and a single-board lid rather than one glued from several strips. Quantity 40. Ask for one sample first.

Useful search terms: 桐箱 オーダーメイド / 桐箱 別注 / 桐箱 製造.

Why paulownia: it is what Japan puts tea bowls, dolls and swords in. It is light, it protects against damp, it is not expensive, and anyone Japanese understands what it means before the lid is even off. Collectors keep the box with the piece. A piece without its original box is worth less.

Note: the Waso osechi box we kept is the same kind of wood but it is a food box, so the walls are thin and the lid just drops in. Ours needs to be better than that.

2. The wooden base

Ask a woodturner for: **40 turned discs, about 9cm across**, in hinoki or keyaki, with a small chamfer on the edge and **shallow blind holes drilled to match the figure's feet** so the figure sits into the base and cannot slide. Send them a figure or exact measurements of the foot positions.

Useful search terms: 木地師 / 木工 ろくろ / 木製 台座 オーダー.

Why this matters more than it sounds: the base makes the figure feel heavier and more serious, it gives your signature somewhere to go, and it stops people noticing it was 3D printed. Most importantly, it means a Japanese craftsman's hands are genuinely on this object rather than us just saying Japan in the description. It is also an easy first commission to write in Japanese, and good practice for approaching the craftspeople we want to work with later.

If Japan is too slow for November, use a UK woodturner for this edition and change for the next one.

3. A small brass stamp of the Auwa mark

One stamp, used on the base, the box lid and the card. Cheap, and it gives us three branded touches from one object.

PART 5 — MAKING ONE FIGURE, START TO FINISH

This is the sequence for every single piece. About two hours.

1. **Print it** with its number embossed underneath (10 min of your time)
2. **Remove supports and clean it up** (10 min)
3. **Sand** 180, 320, 400, 600, paying attention to the top of the head, under the arms, between the legs (30-45 min)
4. **Stain** if it is a Sumi, then let it dry fully (10 min plus drying)
5. **Wax and buff** to a dry, soft sheen (10 min)
6. **Paint the eyes** (8 min)
7. **Check the number** underneath is clean (3 min)
8. **Fit it to its base** and check it seats properly (5 min)
9. **Sign the base** and write the same number on it (2 min)
10. **Write the card** by hand (6 min)
11. **Pack it:** wrap the figure in cloth, lay it in the felt cradle, base flat underneath, card on top, lid on, obi band around, then into the outer carton (14 min)
12. **Label and record** which number went to whom (4 min)

Important: in the box, the figure lies down, it does not stand. Standing puts all the weight on those thin legs for the whole journey. The buyer takes it out and places it on its base themselves, which is a nice moment and makes the object theirs.

PART 6 — TWO THINGS TO SAVE FOR LATER

Your hand-painted surface idea. It is a good one and it will make beautiful pieces. But keep it out of this first edition. Auwa's light reveals what is inside a thing, and the whole collaboration plan depends on sending artists a plain, unpainted Auwa for *them* to reveal. If our own first edition is already painted, then the Fin DAC piece is just another painted one instead of the first reveal. Paint one now as a test, put it away, and let it open the artist series later.

Metal bases. They looked good and they solve the weight problem. But two materials in the first edition makes the story confusing. Save metal for a special piece: brass under an artist edition, black steel under a collaboration. Changing the base is a cheap way to make an edition feel different.

PART 7 — ORDER 40, NOT 30

Order 40 of every part: boxes, bases, wraps, cards, cartons.

Some will break. Some are needed for photography. Some go to press. And several go in parcels to Japanese makers, with the two books, as the way we introduce ourselves.

TIMELINE

- **Now to mid-September:** the three decisions, the six tests, and orders placed for boxes, bases and the stamp
- **Late September:** material, finish and price locked
- **Early October:** three complete pieces exist, box included
- **Mid-October:** Tom photographs
- **Mid-November:** the drop opens, then made to order over about three weeks

The photography cannot start until finished pieces and a real box exist, so everything upstream of it is on the critical path.